

Tree Borrows

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Rust's type system provides powerful optimizations

```
fn write_both(x: &mut i32, y: &mut i32) -> i32 {  
  
    *x = 13;  
  
    *y = 20;  
  
    *x  
  
}
```

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mutable thus disjoint

*x is unchanged

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```

mutable thus disjoint

*x has known value

*x is unchanged

always returns 13

Rust's type system provides powerful optimizations

```
fn write_both(x: &mut i32, y: &mut i32) -> i32 {  
  
    *x = 13;  
  
    *y = 20;  
  
    13 // formerly *x: one fewer load from memory  
  
}
```

Type-level guarantees for references



`&mut` → mutation, no aliasing

`&` → aliasing, no mutation

Escape hatch: **unsafe**

Can **bypass typechecks** to implement **low-level manipulations**

```
unsafe {  
    // Code within this block has relaxed typechecking  
    . . .  
}
```

Within **unsafe** it is **the programmer's responsibility** to check

- that pointers are non-null
- that memory is initialized
- ...

What if **unsafe** code is misused ?

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fn write_both(x: &mut i32, y: &mut i32) -> i32 {  
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    *y = 20;  
    *x  
}
```

```
fn main() {  
    let mut root = 42;  
    let ptr = &raw mut root;  
    let x = unsafe { &mut *ptr };  
    let y = unsafe { &mut *ptr };  
    println!("{}", write_both(x, y));  
}
```


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Not the compiler's responsibility

Within **unsafe** it is **the programmer's responsibility** to check

- that pointers are non-null
- that memory is initialized
- compliance with aliasing rules **NEW!**

Tree Borrows (TB): defines those aliasing rules

Not the compiler's responsibility

Within `unsafe` it is the programmer's responsibility to check

- that pointers are non-null
- that memory is initialized

- **Sounds familiar?**

Stacked Borrows has the same purpose,
Tree Borrows is its successor.

Stacked Borrows (SB)

In safe Rust, the Borrow Checker makes borrows well-bracketed. Stacked Borrows extends the well-bracketedness to **unsafe**.

```
let mut root = 42;  
let ptr = &raw mut root;  
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Desired outcome: UB

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A diagram showing a memory stack. It consists of a single rectangular box with the word "root" inside. The box has a double-line border, with the top line being thicker than the bottom line.

- new stack at root

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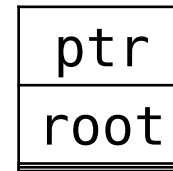
root

- ✓ root is at the top

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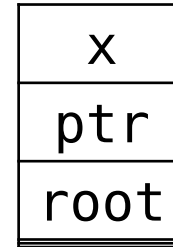


- ✓ root is at the top
- push ptr

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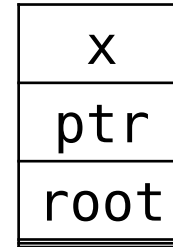


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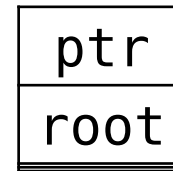


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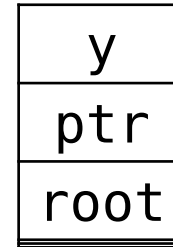


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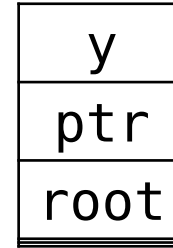


- pop until ptr is at the top
- push y

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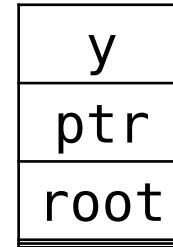
- search for x

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```

UB!



Can't use x if it is not in the stack

Desired outcome: UB

SB was **implemented** in Miri (official interpreter and UB detector)

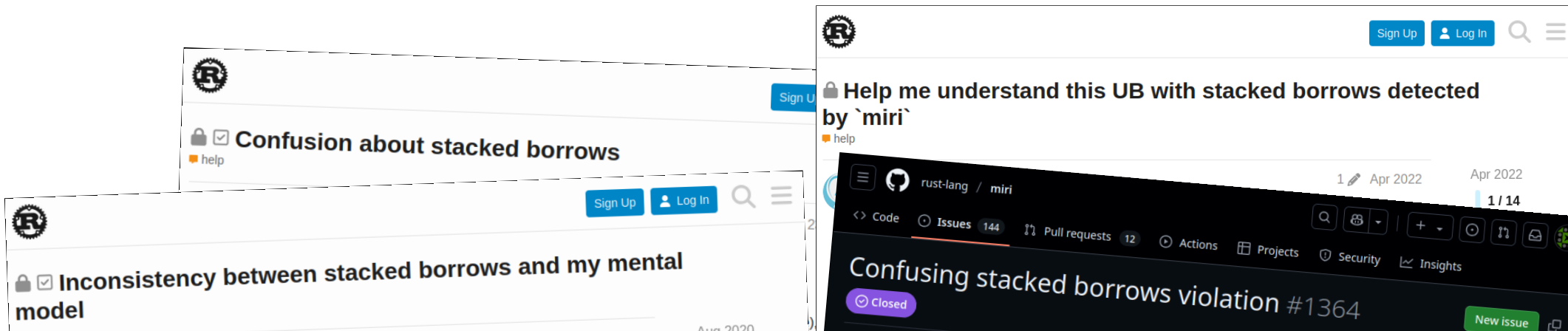
→ included in many projects' CI

→ several bugs detected (e.g. in stdlib)

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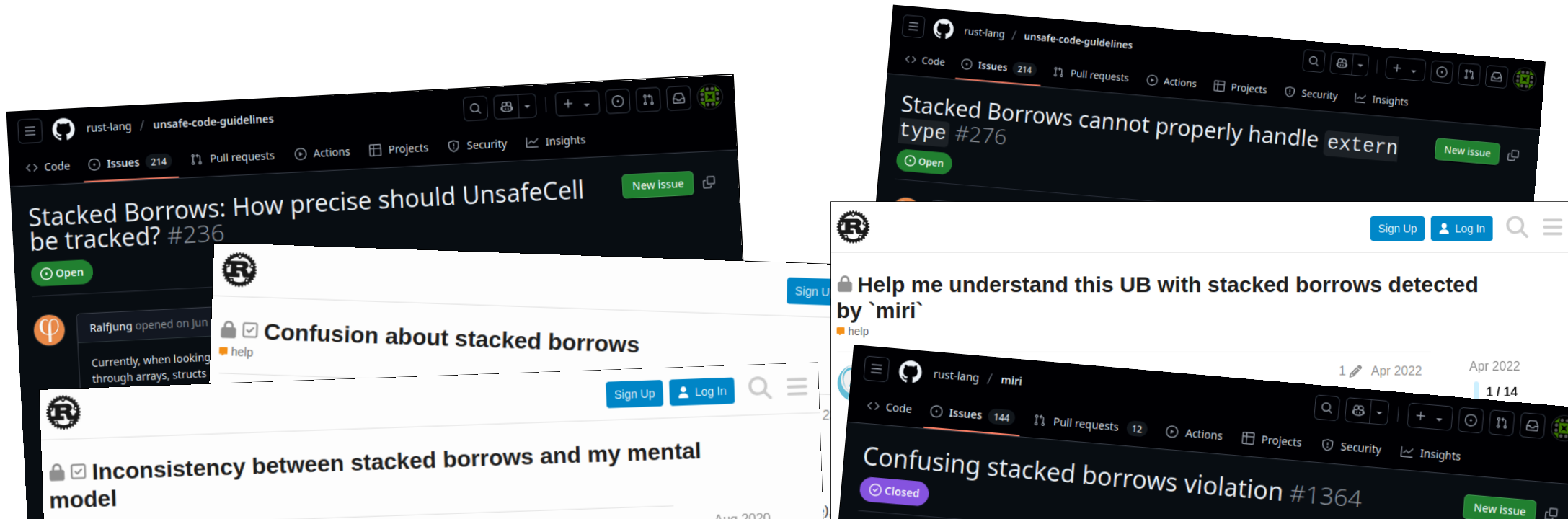
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Stacked Borrows: asserting uniqueness too early?
Should we allow the optimizer to add spurious
stores? #133

Open

rust-lang / unsafe-code-guidelines

<> Code Issues 214 Pull requests Actions Projects Security Insights

Storing an object as &Header, but reading the
data past the end of the header #256

New issue

Open

rust-lang / unsafe-code-guidelines

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Stacked Borrows: raw pointer usable only for T
too strict? #134

Open

rust-lang / unsafe-code-guidelines

<> Code Issues 214 Pull requests Actions Projects Security Insights

Stacked Borrows: How precise should UnsafeCell
be tracked? #236

Open



Ralfjung opened on Jun
Currently, when looking
through arrays, structs

Confusion about stacked borrows

help



Inconsistency between stacked borrows and my mental
model

New issue

rust-lang / unsafe-code-guidelines

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Stacked Borrows: Disabled has more effects than
expected #274

Open



Stacked Borrows incompatible with Garbage Collectors?

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There

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Stacked Borrows cannot properly handle extern
type #276

Open



Help me understand this UB with stacked borrows detected
by `miri`

help

rust-lang / miri

<> Code Issues 144 Pull requests 12 Actions Projects Security Insights

Confusing stacked borrows violation #1364

Closed

New issue

Anecdotal evidence supported by data:

- analysis of 30 000 libraries
- 6000+ tests that otherwise work are declared UB under Stacked Borrows

Tree Borrows allows much more code

Stacked Borrows (SB)

Tree Borrows uses a **tree** instead of a stack to track borrows

Out of 30 000 most downloaded libraries,
> **50% fewer** tests with aliasing UB when using Tree Borrows

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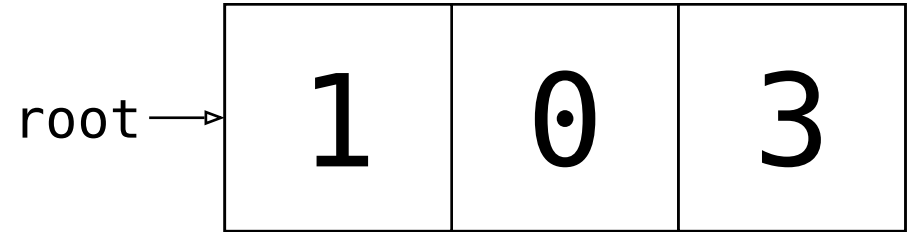
fixes known technical limitations of SB, incl. **pointer offsets**

From Stacks to Trees

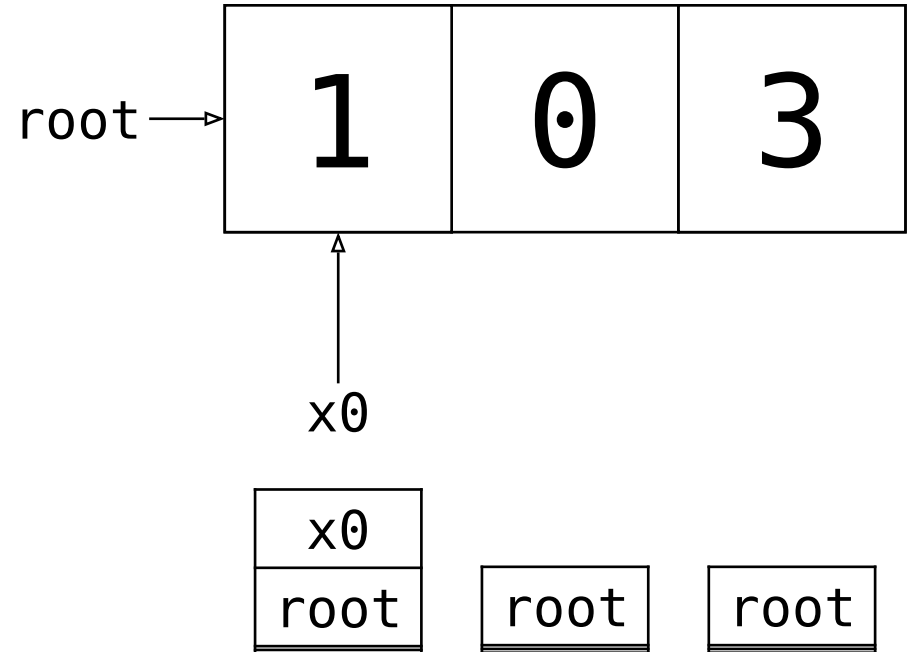
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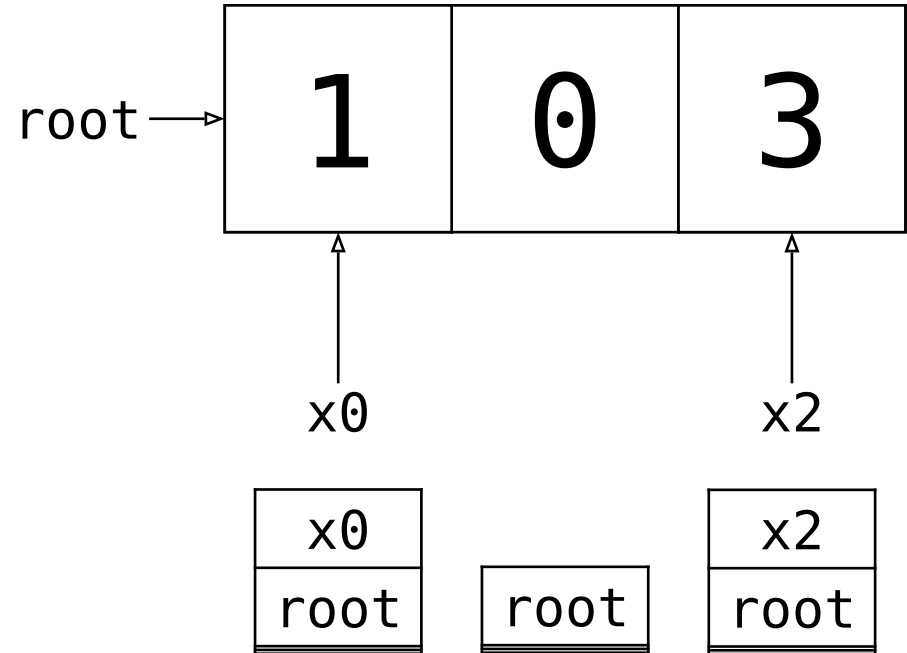
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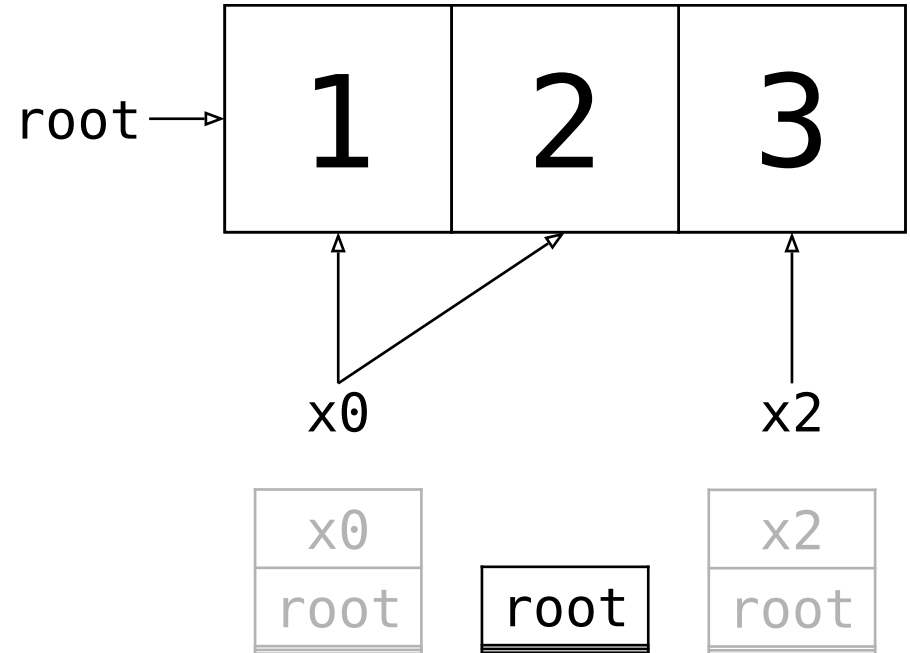


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```
// Scenario 1
```

```
unsafe { *x0.add(1) = 2; }
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Desired outcome: not UB

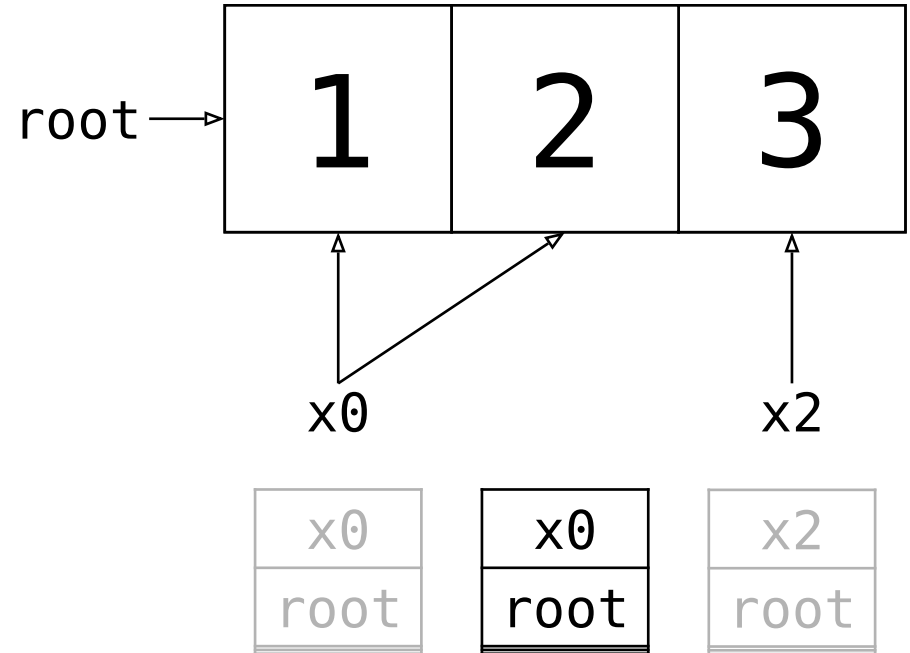


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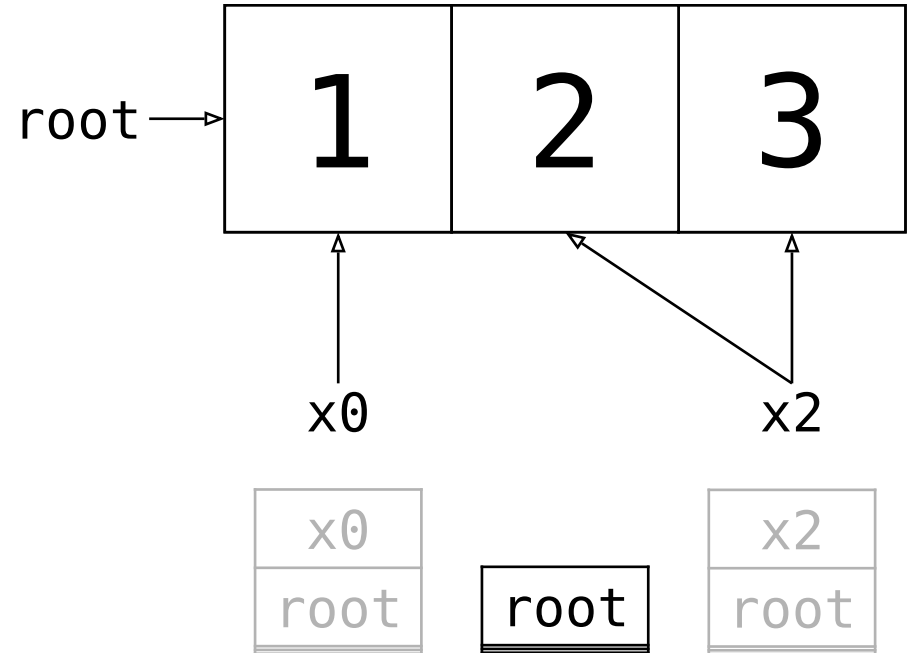


```
let mut root = vec![1, 0, 3];
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```

```
// Scenario 2
```

```
unsafe { *x2.sub(1) = 2; }
```

Desired outcome: not UB

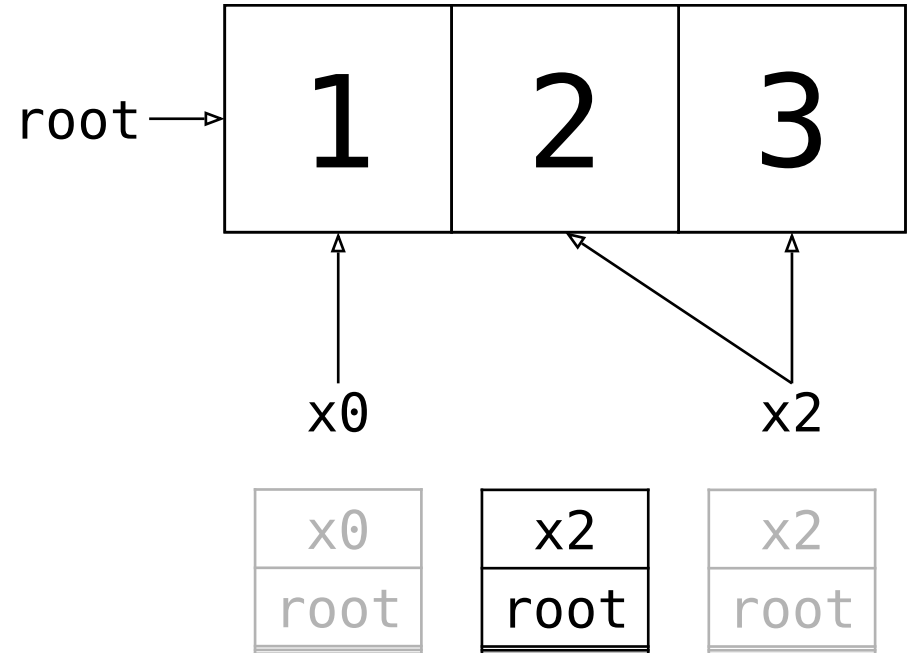


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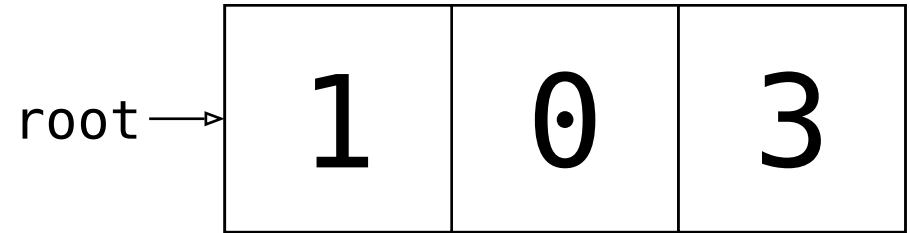
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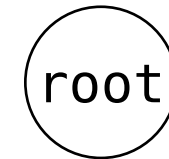
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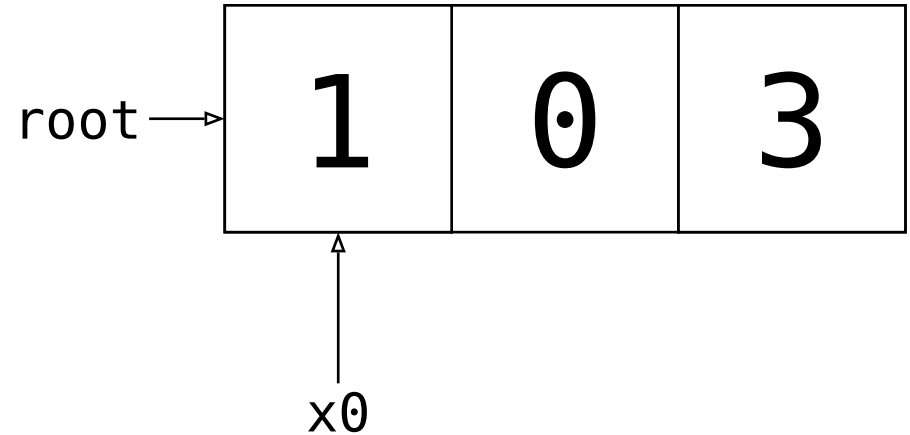

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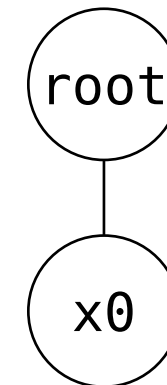
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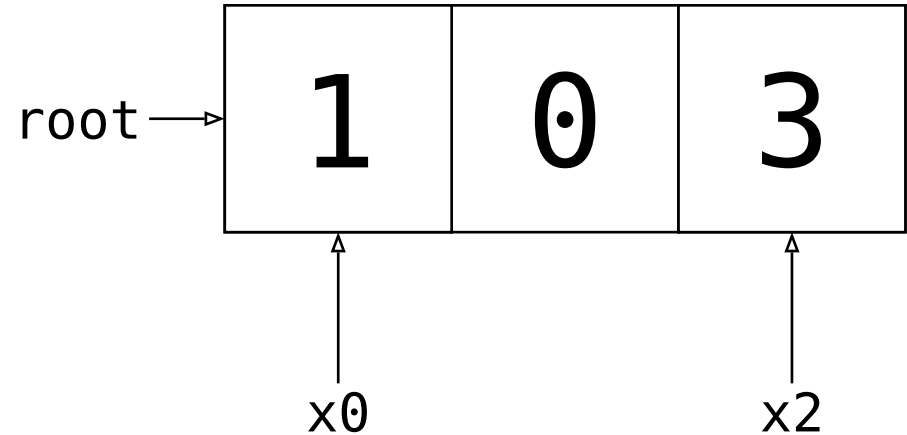
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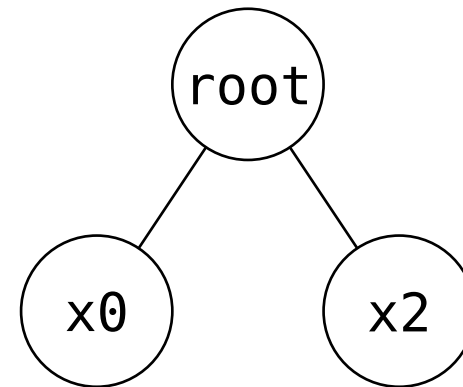
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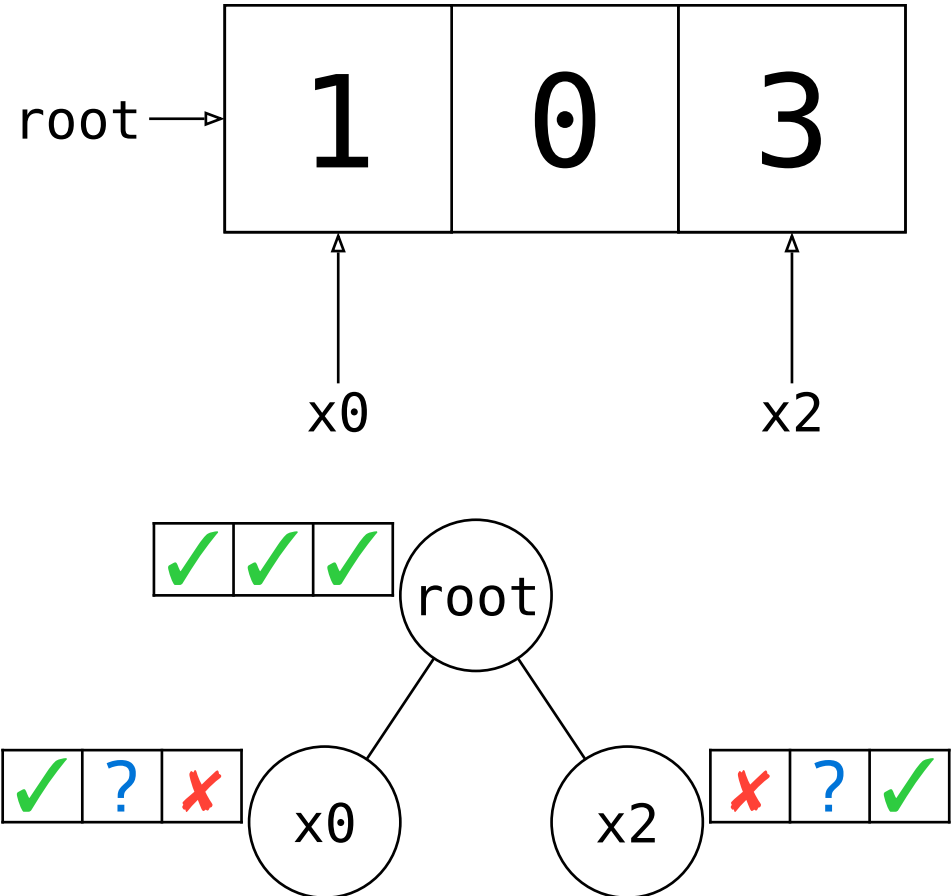


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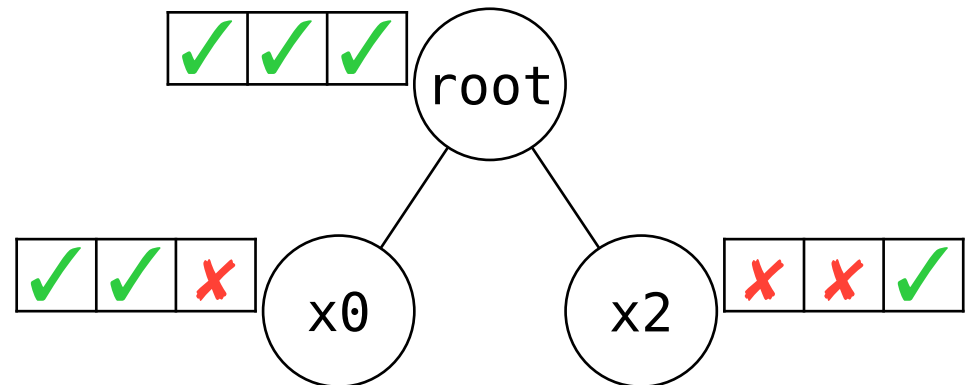
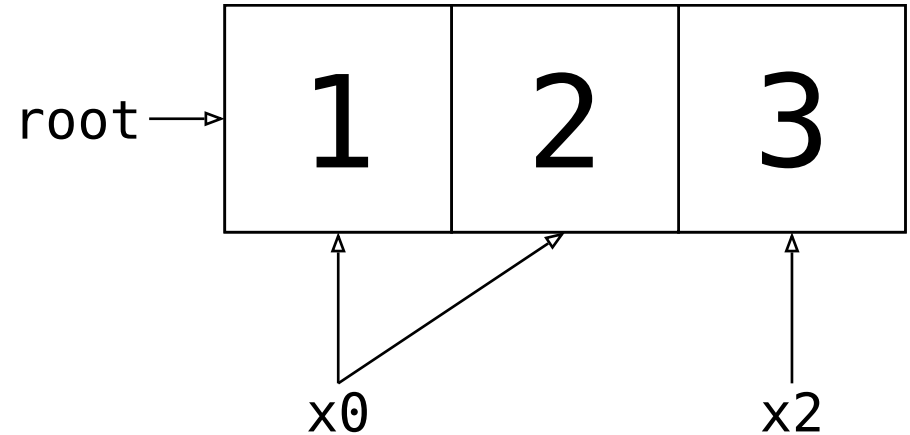


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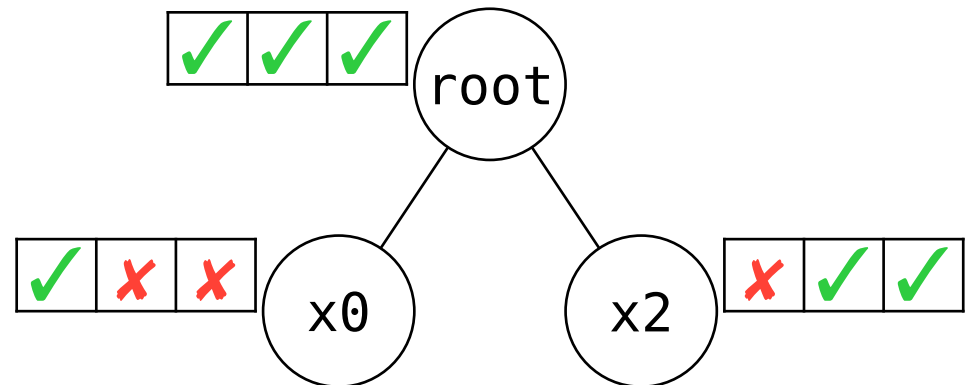
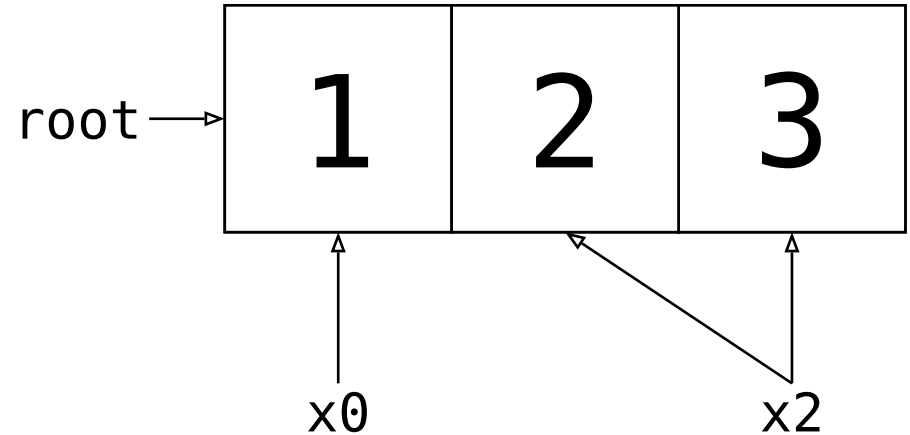


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// Scenario 2

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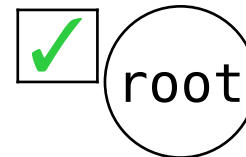
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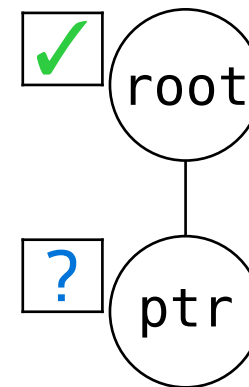


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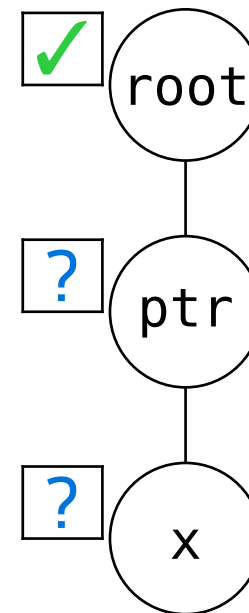


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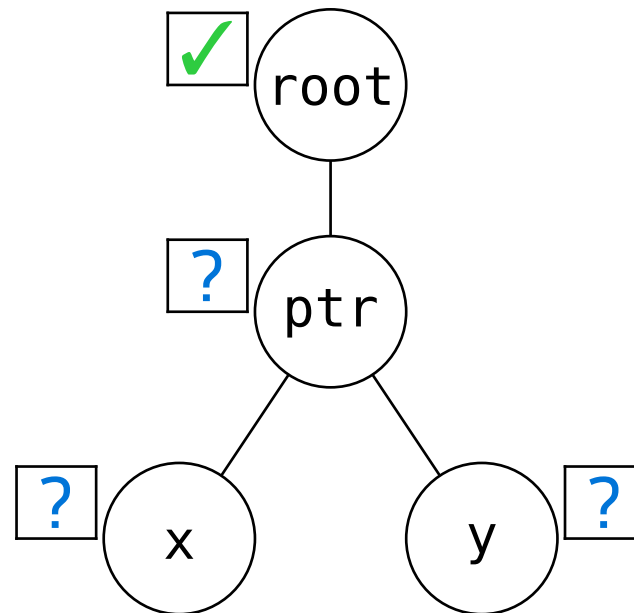


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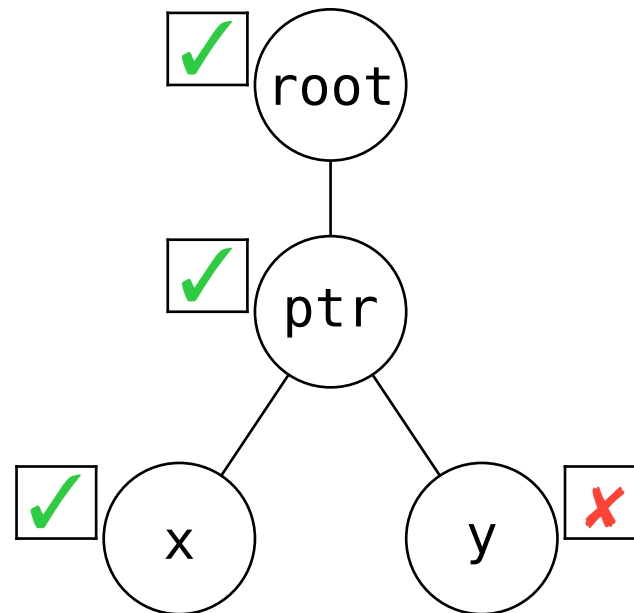


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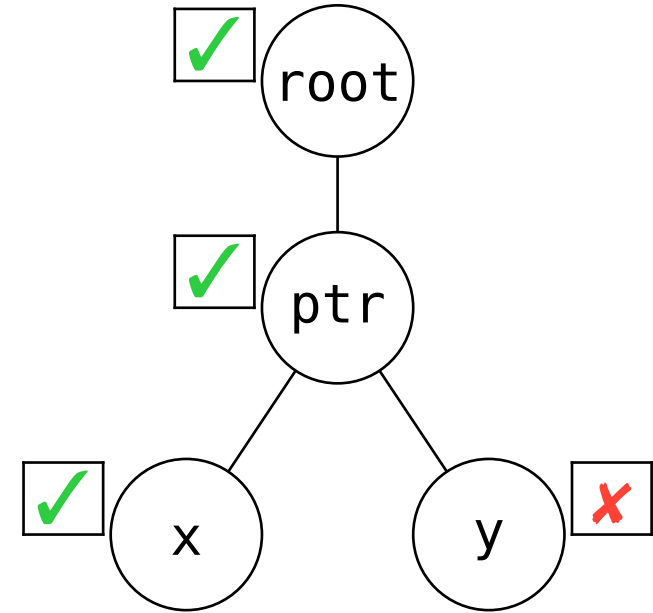
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UB!



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Evaluation

TB should enable desired optimizations

i.e. have enough UB to rule out problematic patterns

- formalized in Rocq (+Simuliris)
- a selection of optimizations proven
 - ✓ delete read through `&mut` or `&`
 - ✓ insert read through `&` in function
 - ✓ move read down for `&mut` or `&` in function
- ...

It should be possible to write **unsafe** code free of UB Evaluation

i.e. UB should be predictable and not too common

Tree Borrows finds 50% fewer cases of aliasing UB

Only 31 ($< 0.01\%$) tests are regressions, all easily fixable.

(Out of 30 000 libraries, 400 000+ working tests)

“Tree Borrows accepts more real-world programs that call foreign functions than Stacked Borrows due to differences in handling pointer arithmetic.”

A Study of Undefined Behavior Across Foreign Function Boundaries in Rust Libraries,
by I. McCormack, J. Sunshine, J. Aldrich @ ICSE'25

Conclusion

Try it out:

Rust Playground supports TB
play.rust-lang.org



Learn more:

[plf.inf.ethz.ch/research/
pldi25-tree-borrows.html](https://plf.inf.ethz.ch/research/pldi25-tree-borrows.html)

- detailed state machine
- raw pointers
- interior mutability

